woman contributed enough to buy a helicopter—and helped buy advertising to counter the Sandinistas' Madison Avenue disinformation campaign. I regarded them as patriots, people from the grass roots of America who were voluntarily trying to bring to our neighbors in Central America the same kind of freedom we enjoyed in the United States.

It was only later, when the Tower Board and Congress completed their investigations, that I learned that some on the NSC staff had gone farther to help the Contras than I was aware of.

Let me be clear. I wanted the Contras maintained as a force, to the fullest extent that was legal, until I could convince Congress to appropriate new funds for the freedom fighters; but I was distressed by the investigations' conclusions that the NSC staff had been so heavily involved in the Contra operation. Press reports appeared suggesting that the NSC and the CIA had gone beyond limits set by the Boland Amendment, and were conducting what some members of Congress claimed was an illegal war in Nicaragua. When I inquired about this, I was told the reports were inaccurate. I later repeated some of these assurances to the American people, and assured them we had been abiding by the law.

In 1986, an American was shot down over Nicaragua with a plane loaded with supplies bound for the Contras. I read a newspaper account of this incident and asked about the report. I was told that this individual had no affiliation with our government; I told the American people that. Later, of course, I learned that the flight had been a supply mission apparently arranged by people reporting to the NSC. When reports were published about other alleged illegal activities by the U.S. government in Central America, Bill Casey said the articles were wrong or distorted, and I accepted that. I trusted and believed in Casey, who had taken an agency that during the previous administration had become badly